the ffdshow configuration window. Click on `Keys & remote`. Click the `Keyboard control` checkbox; you'll see all the effects and features that can be enabled through shortcuts. You can double-click on any one of the effects to change the shortcut. Hold down `[Ctrl]`, `[Alt]`, and `[Shift]` along with the key for the effect to toggle it. This feature can be especially useful in cases when you want your processing settings that you earlier set up to be enabled instantly.

If you want to see the status of all the effects currently in use, you can enable the OSD feature in ffdshow. Click the `OSD` checkbox. By default, some other information will be displayed. Disable these details by un-checking the boxes and clicking OK. Now, every time you enable an effect, a notification will appear on the screen for a short duration. Settings for the font used on the OSD can be changed from the Font menu.

ffdshow's Audio Decoder

ffdshow's Audio Decoder component can be used to play back all music formats. You will need to set your media players to use ffdshow. For example, in Winamp, go to `Options > Plug-ins > Input`. Double-click on `Nullsoft DirectShow Decoder`. Add the formats that you want ffdshow to use separated by a semicolon, for example: `MP3;MP4` Click `Close`.

Now when you play a song in Winamp, you should see the ffdshow Audio Decoder icon in the System Tray. All the effects can be viewed and settings changed by first clicking on ffdshow Audio Decoder. The different plugins can be enabled by checking on the boxes next to the names. The rest of the functionality is similar to that in ffdshow Video Decoder.

Using Winamp Plugins

When you use ffdshow on other media players, it gives you the option to use Winamp's inbuilt plugins, like special equalisers. Start the ffdshow Audio Decoder. Click the `Winamp 2` checkbox to enable this plugin. Locate the path for the Winamp folder using the button at the top. All the plugins will be listed in the drop-down menu at the bottom of the window. Choose the plugin you want to use. In this case, we'll use the Shibatch Super Equalizer. Click on `Configure` to set the options for the plugin. Click `OK` when done.

Using The Inbuilt Equaliser And Importing Winamp Presets

You can also use the inbuilt equaliser instead of Winamp's by clicking on the `Equalizer` checkbox. Make any changes to the equaliser and click `OK`. You can also load presets from the Winamp equaliser. Assuming you saved the equaliser settings to an EQF file, click on the `Load Winamp preset` button. Browse to the location. Enter the File name as `*.eqf` and point to the file you saved. A small entry should appear next to the button. Click it to load the preset. Click `OK` when done.

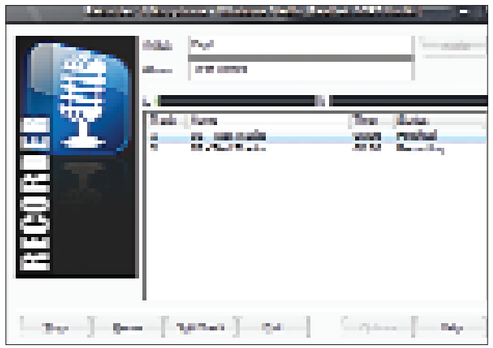
J RIVER MEDIA JUKEBOX 12

Some of us are used to Winamp, and some have stuck with Windows Media Player... but don't forget that there are alternatives. J River Media Jukebox 12 is one of the latest releases of the Media Jukebox application. It is completely free and fully-functional (unlike J River Media Center). The interface is similar to that of iTunes, and it has a lot of impressive features.

Recording Your Own Tracks

Media Jukebox 12 can record tracks through the line-in or microphone. The Sound Recorder that comes with Windows has a limitation of 60 seconds; Media Jukebox 12 doesn't.

To start the recorder, go to `Tools > Advanced Tools > Record Sound...`. Click on Options to configure the settings. Click on `Encoding` to see the encoder settings. Click on the `Encoder` drop-down button and select a codec that you want to use. Click `Encoder Settings` to set the advanced options for that encoder—quality profiles and the bitrates. Click on `Recorder` to select the input settings. Select the device and the source—it could be a line-in or microphone or mixer. Set a higher recording volume if your microphone isn't loud enough. When done, click OK. Click `Start` to start to start recording. You can split a continuous recording into multiple tracks by clicking on `Split Track` at any time.



Media Jukebox 12 comes with an inbuilt recorder so you can record your own tracks

Downloading Cover Art For Albums

When we collect music, we generally sorting and rename it in an orderly manner. Almost all well-known media players have support for cover art, which is displayed alongside the song playing. Click on the `Playing Now` link on the left, and the album art for the song and album will be displayed at the top of the playlist.

Most media players don't download covert art for you; you are to depend on a standalone application for downloading album covers and then set it for each album. Media Jukebox 12 can download the album art for all songs and albums. To download album art, select all the songs and albums from the playlist, right click-on it, and click `Cover Art > Get From Internet...` Click `OK` and the images will be downloaded. Depending on the number of songs, it can take a while. You can also acquire the cover art using a scanner—click on `Get From Scanner...` to do that. If you find a good album cover while you're browsing the Internet, you can copy it to your clipboard. Right-click on an image in your browser and click `Copy`. Right click on a song and click on `Cover Art > Paste from Clipboard`. You can also use an image URL.

Album View

Assuming you have all your music sorted into albums and all the album art downloaded, you can use the Album View, which displays a very attractive presentation of all your music. Click on Audio from the left menu, then click on the View menu and then on `View Settings > Album Thumbnails`. You can double-click on any of the albums to start playing all the tracks on it. You can also choose how many album covers should be displayed on a page. Use the slider at the top right of the window to alter the number of covers displayed.

Switching To Full-screen View

Media Jukebox 12 has a dedicated full-screen mode, which can be useful as a dedicated media playback system. The full screen can be used for navigation mode, and the cover art we just talked about can be displayed as a full-screen image. You can double-click on the visualisation being displayed at the bottom left of the screen to switch to full-screen mode.

The arrow keys can be used to control the playback and visualisations. Use the up and down keys to change the type of control—playback, visualisation, volume, etc. Use the left and right keys to change the value.

A Game In J River Media Jukebox!

One of the visualisations that come with Media Jukebox 12 has a game in it—Pong! By default, the visualisation has both players as AI, but you can control the left paddle by pressing `[W]` to move it up and `[S]` to move it down.

Downloading Podcasts

J River Media Jukebox can manage and download podcasts and then play them whenever you want. Click on `Podcasts` to access the podcasts feature. If you know the address of the RSS feed for a podcast, click on `Add New Feed`. Enter a name and the exact URL for the RSS feed. Click `OK`. You can also use Google search to browse and find podcasts feeds right through Media Jukebox.

Once you have the podcasts added to your list, you'll find them under the Podcast link to the left. You can choose to have all the podcasts automatically downloaded, or you can manually download the podcasts you want. To download a podcast, click on the `Download` link in the `Episode Status` column in the podcast of your choice. To have podcasts automatically downloaded, click the `Edit This Feed` button at the top. Use the `Download` drop-down menu and select `All Episodes` to download all the episodes.

Using Smart Playlists

The Smart Playlist is a unique, and an equally useful feature in Media Jukebox. It allows you to filter out music very accurately. So for example, you can have a list of all the songs in your library that are 192 kbps and from 2007. To add a new smart playlist, right-click on `Playlists` and click `Add Smartlist`. Choose the parameter by clicking on the `Rules` drop-down menu, and enter a suitable value. In this case, choose `Bitrate` and enter the value as 192. Multiple rules can be added in the same manner by clicking the `Add New Rule` button, so we add another rule—`Year`, and the value as `2007`. There are also lists of preset rules that can be added by clicking on `Add Stock Rule` button.

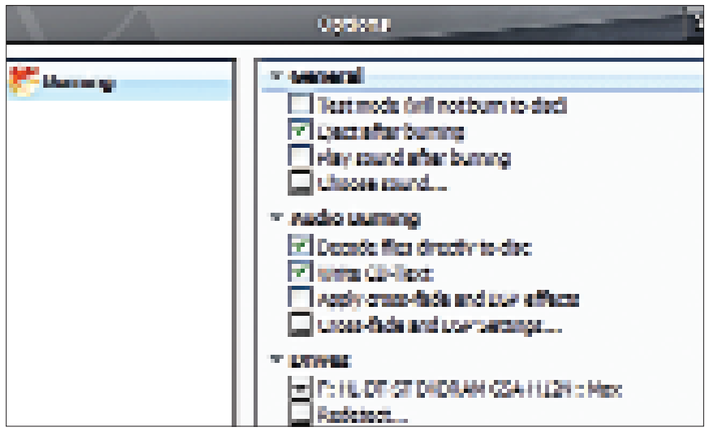
Auto-renaming Tracks

Our music collections are often not titled properly, and the files have random names. You can have MP3s renamed using the ID3 tag data in the files or vice versa. To do this, first select the files you want to rename. Right-click on the selected files and click `Library Tools > Fill Properties` from `Filename` to have the tags filled with information from the filenames, or click `Rename Files from Properties` to use the ID3 tag information to rename the files. From the drop-down menus, you can choose one of the fixed presets that suits the way your files have been named. The same can be done while converting title details to filenames.

Creating Audio CDs

Media Jukebox can create Audio CDs as well as standard MP3 CD or DVDs with its inbuilt CD / DVD burning feature. Click on the `Action` tab on the left and choose `Burn Disc`. Choose whether you want to burn a Data CD or an Audio CD. If you use the Data CD or DVD, you can even use it to burn data files like you would in any CD / DVD burning application. Just beware that Media Jukebox doesn't include subdirectories when you choose the files and folders to be burned. Drag and drop the files you want to burn on the disc. Click on `Burn` to burn the disc. Before you do that, you can customise and change the settings for the writer. Click on `Details` to see the sequence of songs on the CD. You can drag and drop them in the order you want them to be in.

If you click on `Options > Burn Settings`, you can choose the speed that the disc should be burnt at. Click on the drop-down next to the drive and choose the speed.



The Audio CD burning feature can be used to burn data CDs and DVDs as well

Creating CD Labels

J River Media Jukebox 12 comes as a 12 MB installer, and it includes everything—a CD / DVD writing feature and even a CD Label Creator. The CD Label Creator feature is great for burning Audio CDs. The software can create a cover for your discs and for the labels discs cover as well.

First select the tracks that you plan on putting on the CD by holding down the `[Ctrl]` and `[Shift]` keys. Then, go to `Tools > Advanced Tools > Disc Labeler`. At any time, you can get a preview of the finished print by clicking on the `Preview` button. Themes for the print can be selected by clicking on the `Themes` dropdown menu. The CD Info option will show you the list of songs and the name of the artist and CD titles which you can change. The last three menus on the left have customisation options for the front, back cover, and the CD label. In each one of them, you have the option to use the cover art as the background for the label and also a listing of the tracks on the CD. You can also click on `Go To Label Editor` to be able to modify every detail of the design and label.

Using iPod Support

Music Jukebox 12 can also sync with most iPods. Connect your iPod like you normally would and start Media Jukebox 12; your iPod should be detected by the program. If it hasn't detected it, go to `Tools > Options > Handheld`. Click on `Redetect all devices` to detect the devices. Now, click on `Drives and Devices`, and you should see your iPod in the list—and all the songs and media on it. You can now drag and drop songs into your iPod. iPod users can now acquire album art for their songs and then transfer it to their iPods and have cover art displayed on them.

This same feature can be used for non-iPod music players. You can set the folder or location on the player's drive under `Tools > Options > Handheld`. Click `Add Device` and give it a name. Next, click on `Browse` and choose the location of the media player. Click `OK`.